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abriel Magalhaes' (**left**) first World Cup, if selected, would come after a long wait for a defender who has already become central to one of Europe's strongest club backlines. The Arsenal centre-back was not part of Brazil's squad for Qatar 2022, when he was still uncapped at the senior level, but he has since moved closer to the heart of the national team setup.

His senior debut for Brazil came in September 2023, in a 5-1 win over Bolivia at the start of the 2026 World Cup qualifying cycle.

Brazil secured its place at the 2026 World Cup through the CONMEBOL route under Carlo Ancelotti. Gabriel was part of the wider defensive pool during the campaign, although fitness interruptions have also marked his

international run, including a withdrawal from Brazil's March 2026 squad because of a knee issue.

At Arsenal, however, his importance is not in doubt. Since arriving from Lille in 2020, Gabriel has grown into Mikel Arteta's first-choice centre-back and forged one of Premier League's best defensive partnerships with William Saliba. The media has often described the duo as the cornerstone of Arsenal's resurgence, while also noting Gabriel's value as a set-piece threat.

He signed a new contract in June 2025, committing himself to Arsenal until 2029. Last season, his hamstring injury was seen as a major blow to Arsenal's title challenge and Champions League run — a measure of how much its defensive structure depends on him.

Gabriel Magalhaes

BRAZIL

Age 28

Club - Arsenal

Int. caps - 17

